



“I have as
much muscle
as any man ...
[and] can do as
**much work
as any man.**”

SOJOURNER TRUTH, AT THE WOMEN'S RIGHTS CONVENTION
IN AKRON, OHIO, MAY 1851

SPEAKING OUT

Feminist and abolitionist activist Sojourner Truth was born Isabella Baumfree c.1797 to slave parents. After escaping and gaining freedom in 1826, Truth became one of the few African American women to speak publicly against slavery and for women's rights. In May 1851, she gave a rousing speech—later known as “Ain't I a Woman”—at the Ohio Women's Rights Convention in response to male ministers' claims of female inferiority. Truth supposedly pointed to her own muscles, gained in years of slave labor, to demonstrate a woman's strength. One common task for both male and female slaves in the South was picking cotton (left), which African American men and women continued to do for a living even after slavery was abolished.